

THE FAITH CENTER PRESENTS

CHOSEN

THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

CHARACTER EMBODIMENT WORKBOOK

◆ CAST EDITION ◆

DON'T PLAY THE STORY. LIVE IT.

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THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

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CAST EDITION

DON'T PLAY THE STORY. LIVE IT.

Your character does not know what happens next.
Build the world through what you notice, hear, touch, want, fear, and do.

The Faith Center • 2026 Production

WELCOME TO THE WORLD OF CHOSEN

This workbook is designed to help you inhabit your character rather than simply deliver lines, songs, and choreography. Our goal is specificity: even in silence, the audience should sense who you are, what you need, whom you know, and how this world feels to you.

YOU ARE NOT IN A CHRISTMAS MUSICAL.

You do not know what happens next. Do not play the ending. Live what is happening now.

How to use this workbook

Bring it to character and scene-work rehearsals. Mark discoveries in pencil or notes. You are not expected to invent an answer simply because a blank exists; write DISCOVER IN REHEARSAL when the truthful answer has not emerged yet.

The Five Senses

SEE	What does your character notice first?
HEAR	Which sounds mean home, work, danger, comfort, or change?
SMELL	What scents connect to work, household, community, or memory?
TASTE	What suggests hospitality, comfort, celebration, or scarcity?
TOUCH	Which textures and objects do your hands know without thinking?

Rehearsal safety

All embodiment work is imagination-based, consent-based, age-appropriate, and grounded in fictional circumstances. No actor is expected to disclose personal trauma, painful memories, or private experiences. Physical contact is choreographed and agreed upon. Sensory materials are used only when safe for the company.

Historical or sensory details in this workbook are rehearsal choices unless the script establishes them. They are tools for acting, not claims of historical fact.

MARY

“I can be afraid and still say yes.”

Your world begins with an ordinary future you can picture: Joseph, marriage, home, family, familiar streets. Then you are asked to move forward without knowing where the road leads.

SEE	Faces first. Joseph across a crowded marketplace. Your friends. Fabric. The unfinished things that belong to the future you imagine.
HEAR	Familiar voices, laughter, marketplace chatter, Joseph working. Later, whispers begin to sound different.
SMELL	Rehearsal choices: bread, cloth, dust, wood from Joseph's work.
TASTE	Simple shared food: the feeling of home and hospitality.
TOUCH	Fabric, the satchel you made, the unfinished table, Joseph's hand.

YOUR BODY: Grounded and open. Do not begin fragile or saintly. When pressure comes, strength may look like stillness.

YOU WANT: The ordinary future you and Joseph imagined.

YOU FEAR: That the people who know you best may no longer believe they know you.

YOUR OBJECT: Fabric or cloth.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: I said yes. I didn't know yes would cost this much.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Handle the same piece of fabric before Gabriel, after Gabriel, after Joseph leaves, and after he returns. Let the event change the object.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

JOSEPH

“If I can understand it, I can build it.”

Wood makes sense. Measure carefully, work honestly, build something strong. You believe you are building more than furniture; you are building a life with Mary. Then something refuses to fit your measurements.

SEE	Angles, alignment, unfinished work, problems that can be repaired—and Mary.
HEAR	Hammer, scrape, measure, mark, cut. Work rhythm tells you the world is functioning.
SMELL	Wood, dust, leather, work.
TASTE	Water after labor; simple food shared with friends.
TOUCH	Wood grain, tool handles, measuring cord, satchel strap, Mary's hand.

YOUR BODY: Move with purpose. Carry, fix, measure, straighten. In crisis, let unfinished actions reveal what words cannot.

YOU WANT: To build a secure life with Mary and protect it.

YOU FEAR: A problem you cannot fix or control.

YOUR OBJECT: Measuring cord or carpenter's tool.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: If I can't fix this, I don't know who I am.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Practice MEASURE → MARK → CUT → SET until automatic. Repeat after Mary's news and after the dream. Notice what changes.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

SHIRA

"I stay."

You read the emotional room. Your gift is not solving Mary; it is remaining present when an outcome cannot be promised.

SEE	Mary's face before her words.
HEAR	The feeling underneath what someone says.
SMELL	Rehearsal choice: cloth and familiar home scents.
TASTE	Shared food and hospitality.
TOUCH	Folded cloth; a friend's hand or shoulder only when welcomed.

YOUR BODY: Stiller than the group. When someone hurts, become more present rather than busier.

YOU WANT: Mary not facing this alone.

YOU FEAR: Being unable to protect someone you love from pain.

YOUR OBJECT: Folded cloth or shawl.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: I cannot fix this, but I can stay.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Have Mary say 'I'm fine' four different ways. Answer what Shira sees, not the sentence.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

TALIA

“I need it to make sense.”

Questions are not the opposite of love. You care enough to distinguish what is known from what is assumed.

SEE	Contradictions and details.
HEAR	Exact wording and gaps in logic.
SMELL	A rehearsal scent associated with order or work.
TASTE	You notice when something is 'off.'
TOUCH	Small objects you can sort or align.

YOUR BODY: Listen forward. Your mind often arrives half a step before your mouth.

YOU WANT: Truth.

YOU FEAR: Believing something only because you want it to be true.

YOUR OBJECT: Beads, stones, or counting pieces.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: I don't understand you. That doesn't mean I'm leaving you.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Sort information into FACT / HEARD / ASSUMED / UNKNOWN before running the scene.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

ADINA

“What do we do next?”

When trouble arrives, your hands and mind begin preparing. Care often looks like practical action.

SEE	The next practical problem.
HEAR	Missing information.
SMELL	Food, household work, preparation.
TASTE	Hospitality: has everyone eaten?
TOUCH	Baskets, folded materials, things that need arranging.

YOUR BODY: Often beginning the next task while others are still discussing the current one.

YOU WANT: To protect people through preparation.

YOU FEAR: Being caught unprepared.

YOUR OBJECT: Basket.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: If we can make a plan, maybe this won't hurt as much.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Take 60 seconds to prepare the room for an imaginary emergency while the others interrupt you.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

DAFNA

“If we can laugh, maybe we can breathe.”

You feel tension quickly and often puncture it. The comedy is real, but so is the loyalty beneath it.

SEE	Awkwardness.
HEAR	The silence nobody wants to sit in.
SMELL	An everyday food or market scent.
TASTE	Food can be a comic, social anchor.
TOUCH	A small object you fiddle with while thinking.

YOUR BODY: Quick reactions and expressive impulses. When something truly matters, stillness can become your strongest choice.

YOU WANT: To keep your people emotionally together.

YOU FEAR: Helplessness.

YOUR OBJECT: A small everyday object.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: Sometimes I joke because I don't know how to fix what hurts.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Improvise for laughter. When the director calls TRUTH, drop all comedy immediately.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

LEVI

“Protect what matters.”

Your instinct is protection. When trouble approaches someone you love, you move toward it.

SEE	Threats, disrespect, who has someone's back.
HEAR	Changes in tone.
SMELL	Worksite materials.
TASTE	Shared food with the Brotherhood.
TOUCH	Tools and physical work.

YOUR BODY: Grounded. You naturally occupy space and may position yourself between a friend and a problem.

YOU WANT: To protect Joseph.

YOU FEAR: Watching someone you love be humiliated while you do nothing.

YOUR OBJECT: A substantial work tool.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: If I don't defend my people, who will?

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

During marketplace improvisation, silently classify approaches to Joseph as SAFE / WATCH / PROBLEM.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

MALACHI

“Maybe you don’t know yet.”

You are grounded in faith, but you are not the sermon character. Your strength is often the question that creates room for truth.

SEE	What an argument is hiding.
HEAR	What people avoid saying.
SMELL	Simple work materials.
TASTE	Ordinary shared food.
TOUCH	A simple tool worked patiently.

YOUR BODY: Economical and calm. You do not compete for volume.

YOU WANT: Joseph to separate what he knows from what fear is telling him.

YOU FEAR: Certainty becoming pride.

YOUR OBJECT: A simple hand tool.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: I don’t understand this either. Maybe understanding isn’t the first thing required.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

For five minutes in an improv, give no advice. Questions only.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

CALEB

“Feel first.”

You experience the emotional room quickly. Humor comes easily, but your deeper gift is warmth and staying connected.

SEE	People and reactions.
HEAR	Mood shifts.
SMELL	Worksite and market.
TASTE	Shared food with friends.
TOUCH	Work materials and easy camaraderie.

YOUR BODY: Quick, spontaneous, occasionally imperfect. Let warmth remain when the joke disappears.

YOU WANT: To keep the Brotherhood together.

YOU FEAR: Someone leaving the circle.

YOUR OBJECT: A slightly crooked piece of work.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: I might not know what to say. I can still stay.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Defend an imperfect piece of work as magnificent; then remove the comedy and simply stay beside Joseph.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

EZRA

“What are the facts?”

You notice what does not line up: measurements, patterns, claims, details. Caring may appear through precision rather than speeches.

SEE	Angles, alignment, inconsistencies.
HEAR	Incorrect information.
SMELL	Wood and work materials.
TASTE	Simple, practical routine.
TOUCH	Measuring tools.

YOUR BODY: Precise. You may straighten or reset something without realizing it.

YOU WANT: Coherence.

YOU FEAR: Making an important judgment without enough information.

YOUR OBJECT: Measuring tool.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: I care more than I know how to express.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Let other actors misplace tools during an improv. Quietly notice and reset them without making it a joke.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

ELIZABETH

“Faithful doesn’t mean easy.”

Mary needs somewhere she can breathe. Your presence validates without pretending obedience will be painless.

SEE	Mary's exhaustion.
HEAR	The question beneath the question.
SMELL	Home, food, warm cloth.
TASTE	Hospitality.
TOUCH	Useful household work.

YOUR BODY: Unhurried. You create room instead of demanding it.

YOU WANT: Mary steadied, not dependent.

YOU FEAR: Avoid inventing a fear the script does not require.

YOUR OBJECT: Bowl, cloth, or food-preparation item.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: I know something about waiting for what seemed impossible.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Continue a simple household task while Mary speaks. Let the room feel safe rather than clinical.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

GABRIEL

“The message is enough.”

You do not need to perform 'angel.' The message and the person receiving it are enough.

SEE	Mary completely.
HEAR	Her questions without being threatened by them.
SMELL	No invented sensory signature required.
TASTE	Not required.
TOUCH	Stillness; no prop required.

YOUR BODY: Still, contained, present, unhurried. Remove gestures that compete with meaning.

YOU WANT: To deliver the message clearly.

YOU FEAR: No fear needs to be invented.

YOUR OBJECT: None required.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: Do not invent psychology the script does not give you.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Run the scene once with zero gestures. Restore only movement that becomes necessary.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

NIA

"I notice the story."

Nazareth is not scenery. It is home: shortcuts, personalities, jokes, errands, adults, and children you know.

SEE	Connections and stories beginning.
HEAR	Who is saying what to whom.
SMELL	Market and home.
TASTE	The person who sometimes gives you food.
TOUCH	Whatever belongs to your daily chore.

YOUR BODY: Curious, comfortable, socially fluent.

YOU WANT: To know what is happening around you.

YOU FEAR: Missing something interesting.

YOUR OBJECT: A small chore object.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: There's always something happening here.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Choose your favorite vendor, shortcut, adult who feeds you, adult you avoid, hiding place, and the chore you should be doing.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

SIMON

“I notice what actually happened.”

Where Nia sees a story forming, you often notice the immediate, funny reality. You belong to this town too.

SEE	What people actually did.
HEAR	Things worth repeating.
SMELL	Market and work areas.
TASTE	A familiar treat or shared food.
TOUCH	A chore object or something from the work area you are fascinated by.

YOUR BODY: Direct, curious, uncomplicated.

YOU WANT: To understand and participate in the world around you.

YOU FEAR: Being left out or not knowing what happened.

YOUR OBJECT: A small chore/work object.

PRIVATE THOUGHT: You wouldn't believe what just happened.

ACTOR EXPERIMENT

Choose your own six pieces of Nazareth geography. They cannot all be the same as Nia's.

DISCOVERY NOTE: _____

ENSEMBLE & CHARACTER-GROUP CARDS

NAZARETH ENSEMBLE

You are not background.

Choose an occupation/daily responsibility, one person you are closest to, one minor friction, one need for today, one physical habit, and one harmless piece of information you know. Enter because you have somewhere to go, not because choreography begins.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER / ROMAN PRESENCE

Order is the point.

Your authority is clearest when it is controlled. The decree is simple to you because you do not bear its personal cost. Practice restoring order without simply becoming louder.

BETHLEHEM INNKEEPERS / RESIDENTS

Too much need. Too little room.

Do not begin by playing 'mean.' Decide who is already inside, what resource is running out, and what problem you were solving before Mary and Joseph arrived. Pressure creates the conflict.

SHEPHERDS

Work first. Wonder interrupts it.

Choose a real job: watch, count, repair, keep warm, tend. Do not wait for the angel. Let the extraordinary interrupt ordinary work.

WISE MEN

Reverence without explanation.

Your contribution is visual and ceremonial. Give each journey/gift a distinct inner quality: responsibility, reverence, or curiosity. Let distance traveled live in the body rather than invented dialogue.

ENSEMBLE IDENTITY ASSIGNMENT

Complete what you know. Write DISCOVER IN REHEARSAL where the answer has not emerged yet.

Actor / Character Track	
My Nazareth name	
My stage of life	Child / Teen-young person / Young adult / Adult / Older adult
My household	
My occupation or daily responsibility	
What I am doing when Scene 1 begins	
Where I am trying to get	
What I must accomplish today	
Closest person in Nazareth / how we know each other	
One person who gets on my nerves / why	
What I notice first in the marketplace	
A sound that means home	
A texture my hands know well	

My relationship to Mary	
My relationship to Joseph	
What I think about Mary + Joseph at the beginning	
One harmless thing I know about another villager	
I usually hear news from	
I usually pass the news to	
What I KNOW about the latest rumor	
What I was TOLD	
What I ASSUME	
What I DO NOT KNOW	
My Scene 9 position	Supportive / Supportive but unsure / Conflicted / Skeptical / Judgmental / Watching
When I see Mary in Scene 9, my body wants to	
When I see Joseph in Scene 9, my body wants to	
My recurring object/material	

My private sentence: 'The thing nobody else knows about me is...'	
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SCENE 1 RULE: I am living my day and eventually my day becomes musical.

RELATIONSHIP & OBJECT DISCOVERY

The Relationship Test

At any freeze, be ready to answer: How do I know this person? What do I think of them? What do they know about me? What did I need from them one second before the freeze?

The Same Town

Live the Scene 1 marketplace without dialogue. Freeze. Without changing geography, shift internally to Scene 9. The same people and places now carry different meanings. Let the relationship not generalized 'sadness' or 'judgment' to change your body.

Object Work

Choose one safe recurring object or material. Learn how your hands use it on an ordinary day. Later, handle the same object after the village changes. Do not force emotion; allow circumstances to change behavior.

Discovery Log

Something I discovered about my character tonight:

Something that surprised me:

A relationship discovery I want to remember:

A physical behavior that felt truthful:

Something I still do not understand:

COMPANY REHEARSAL LABS

ENTER YOUR WORLD

Explore your assigned object/material privately. Find out how your character handles it before anyone is watching.

FIVE SENSES OF NAZARETH

Rotate through safe sight, sound, smell, imaginative taste, and touch stations. Ask: Do I need this, ignore it, enjoy it, fear it, work with it, or associate it with someone?

NAZARETH IS ALIVE

Live in the marketplace without scripted dialogue. Work, trade, greet, borrow, negotiate, help, avoid, carry, repair. Everyone needs an objective.

EVERYBODY KNOWS EVERYBODY

Begin with one harmless fact. Let it travel through established relationships. Notice how a true detail can change without anyone deciding to become a villain.

RELATIONSHIP FREEZE

At a freeze, know whom you were looking at, where you were going, what you needed, and what that person knows about you.

THE SAME TOWN

Transform the Scene 1 marketplace into Scene 9 without changing the geography. Let changed relationships tell the story.

THE STANDARD

If the lines disappeared, would we still know who you are, whom you know, what you want, and what just happened to you?